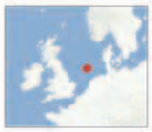
FRENCH REVOLUTIONARY WARS

CAMPERDOWN

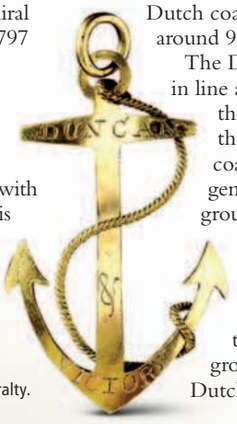


Date October 11, 1797
Forces British: 16 ships of the line, 8 others; Dutch: 16 ships of the line, 9 others
Losses British: none; Dutch: 11 ships captured

Location Off Kamperduin, Netherlands

The Dutch were driven into an alliance with revolutionary France in 1795. Britain responded by blockading the Dutch coast with a naval force under the command of Admiral Adam Duncan. In summer 1797 the difficult operation of maintaining a permanent close blockade was rendered almost impossible as mutinies spread through the Royal Navy, leaving Duncan with only two loyal ships under his command. Meanwhile the Dutch assembled a fleet off the island of Texel, intended to escort troops for an invasion of the British Isles.

Fortunately for the British nothing came of these plans. By October all thought of invasion had been abandoned for the year, but the Dutch government unwisely instructed Vice-Admiral Jan Willem de Winter to stage a sortie from Texel. By this time order had been restored in the British fleet. Most of Duncan's ships were taking on supplies in Yarmouth when news arrived that the Dutch had come out. Duncan immediately set sail for the Dutch coast. He found de Winter around 9:00 a.m. on October 11.



Fouled anchor
This badge honoring the battle of Camperdown features a "fouled anchor" (wrapped in its chain), the traditional symbol of the British Admiralty.

The Dutch sailed toward Texel in line ahead. Desperate to catch them before they reached the shallows off the Dutch coast, Duncan ordered a general pursuit. In two ragged groups, one led by Duncan in *Venerable* and the other by Vice-Admiral Richard Onslow in *Monarch*, the British bore down upon the Dutch line. Onslow's group engaged and broke the Dutch rear, but Duncan's had a far tougher fight with the center and van. *Venerable* was engaged by three Dutch ships and nearly overwhelmed. Duncan was saved by British ships sailing forward from the rear to help their hard-pressed colleagues—one captained by William Bligh, later to face mutiny on the *Bounty*.

Eventually, superior British gunnery prevailed. The Dutch were subdued after more than two hours' battering. De Winter was taken prisoner on his flagship *Vrijheid*, the surrender of his sword graciously refused by Duncan. The defeat ended Dutch pretensions to be a major naval power.

1775–1831

JACK CRAWFORD

SAILOR HERO OF CAMPERDOWN

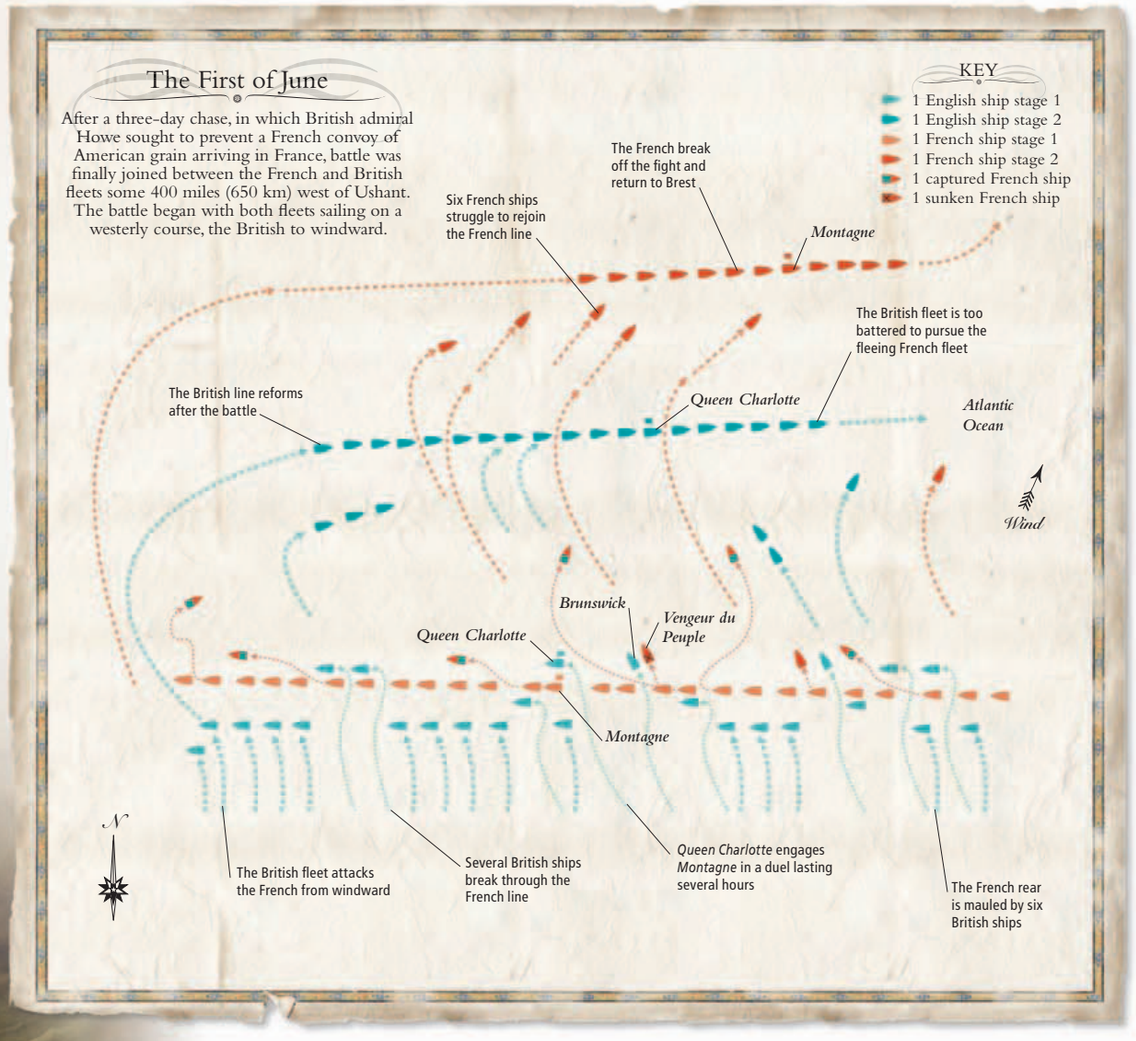
Born in Sunderland, northern England, Jack Crawford worked at sea from boyhood. In 1796 he was pressed into the Royal Navy to serve on board *Venerable*, the flagship of Admiral Adam Duncan. At Camperdown he distinguished himself when *Venerable* was surrounded by enemy ships, including the Dutch flagship *Vrijheid*, and the top of its main mast was shot off, bringing down the admiral's flag. It was imperative to restore the flag aloft, for a failure to do so would be taken as a signal of surrender. Under intense gunfire, at great risk to his life, Crawford climbed the broken mast under fire and nailed the flag to the top of the shattered stump. On his return home Crawford was awarded a silver medal by the people of Sunderland. He was later presented to King George III, who gave him a pension of £30 a year. He died of cholera in 1831.



carnage, but lived long enough to force *Vengeur* to strike. There were many other examples of furious close combat.

Villaret exhibited excellent coolness and judgement. Despite his flagship having by far the worse of the exchange with *Queen Charlotte*, the French admiral succeeded in disengaging and reforming a diminished line to leeward. With a number of the British ships disabled, the French were allowed to escape with a clutch of shattered ships under tow. Howe concentrated on securing the seven French ships that had struck. *Vengeur* proved too badly holed to be saved, sinking with several hundred of its crew still aboard.

When the convoy reached France safely on June 12, the revolutionary government hailed the naval operation as a triumph. Yet the British were surely justified in celebrating the First of June. Fighting an equal force, they had taken seven ships for the loss of none and inflicted three times the casualties they suffered.



Engagement off Ushant
The *Brunswick* (center) is seen in action with the *Vengeur du Peuple* (right) and the *Achille*, left). The *Achille* has lost her masts, and the *Vengeur* is soon to sink, having been holed beneath the waterline.